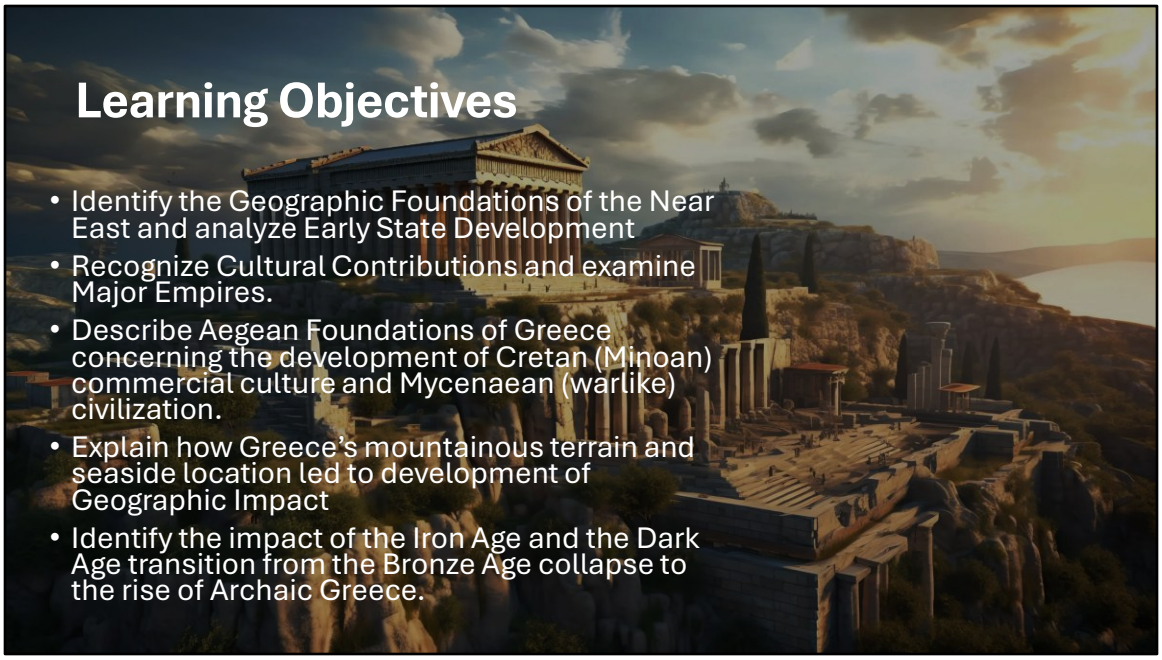
GE 18

Civilization of the Ancient Near East - Greek Civilization

Tracing the development of the Greco-Roman Civilization in Asia, North Africa and Europe

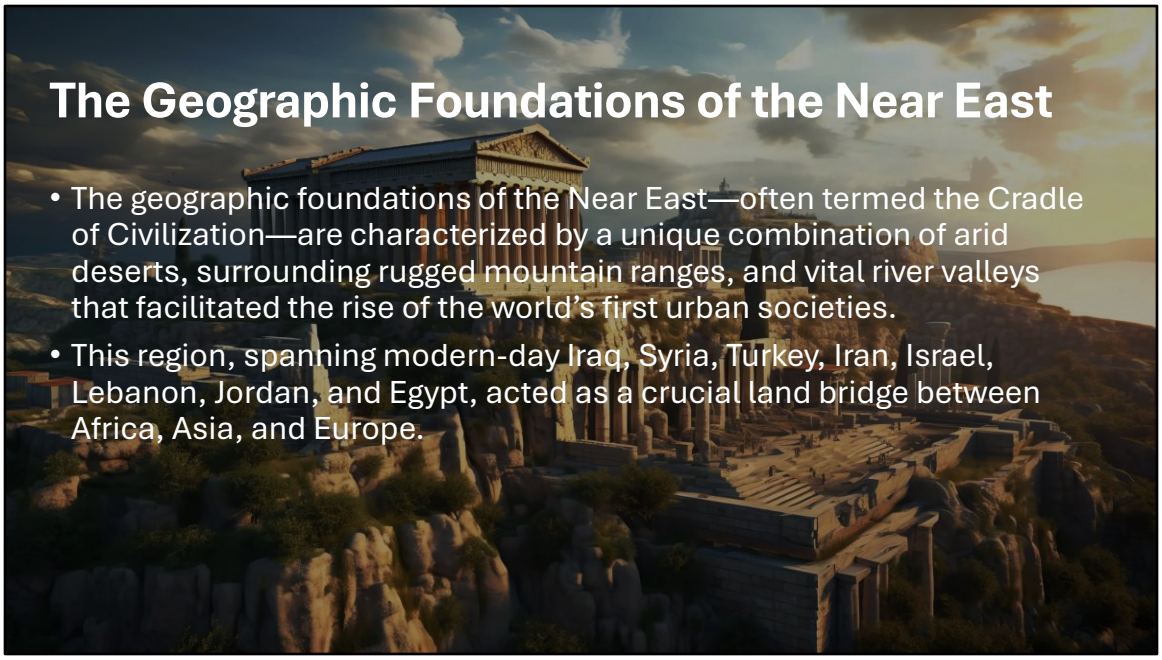


Learning Objectives

- Identify the Geographic Foundations of the Near East and analyze Early State Development
- Recognize Cultural Contributions and examine Major Empires.
- Describe Aegean Foundations of Greece concerning the development of Cretan (Minoan) commercial culture and Mycenaean (warlike) civilization.
- Explain how Greece's mountainous terrain and seaside location led to development of Geographic Impact
- Identify the impact of the Iron Age and the Dark Age transition from the Bronze Age collapse to the rise of Archaic Greece.

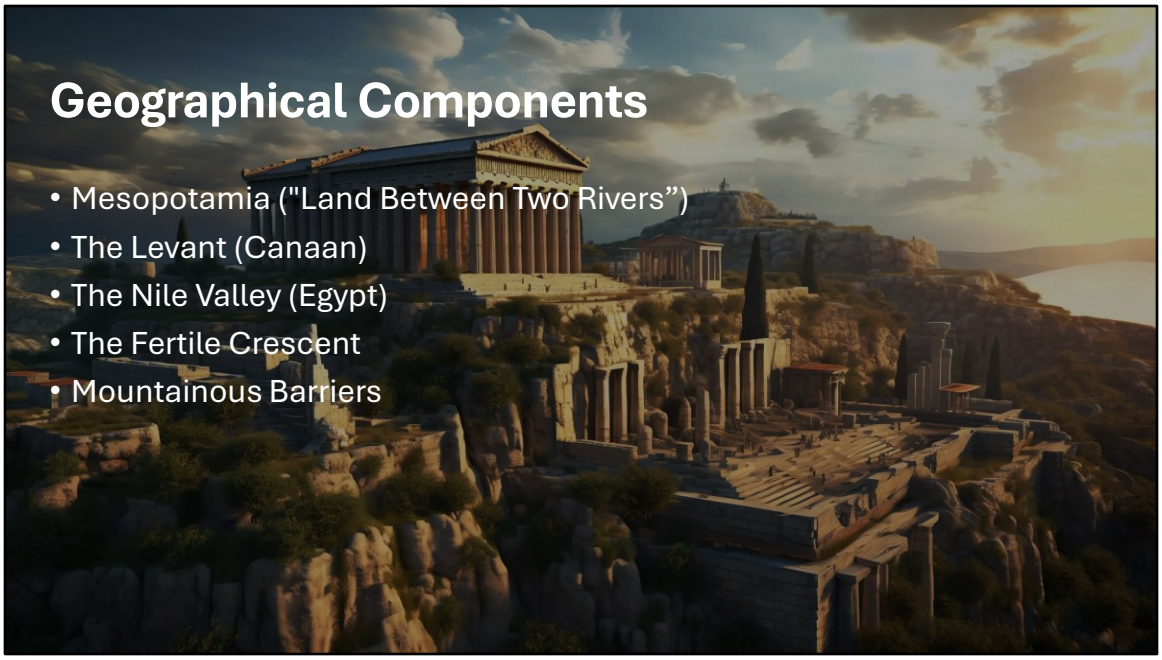
The Near East

- The Near East is a transcontinental region around the Eastern Mediterranean encompassing the historical Fertile Crescent, the Levant, Anatolia, Egypt, Mesopotamia, the Arabian Peninsula, and occasionally the Balkans.
- The term was coined in the 19th century by modern Western geographers and was originally applied to the Ottoman Empire.
- The term Near East was used to refer to the part of the Orient nearest to Europe.



The geographic foundations of the Near East—often termed the Cradle of Civilization—are characterized by a unique combination of arid deserts, surrounding rugged mountain ranges, and vital river valleys that facilitated the rise of the world's first urban societies.

This region, spanning modern-day Iraq, Syria, Turkey, Iran, Israel, Lebanon, Jordan, and Egypt, acted as a crucial land bridge between Africa, Asia, and Europe



Geographical Components

•**Mesopotamia ("Land Between Two Rivers"):** Located in modern Iraq and parts of Syria/Turkey, the Tigris and Euphrates rivers provided the water necessary for large-scale, irrigated agriculture in an otherwise arid climate.

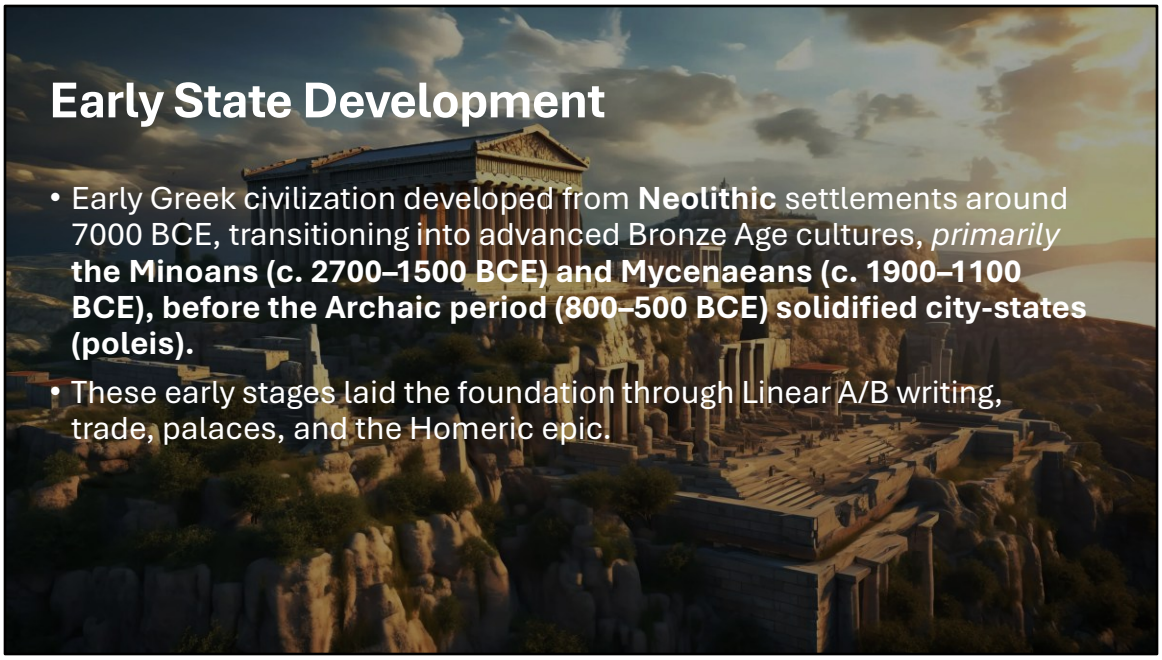
•**The Levant (Canaan):** The eastern Mediterranean strip, bridging Mesopotamia and Egypt, served as a crucial corridor for trade and cultural exchange, bordered by the Mediterranean Sea to the west and the Syrian Desert to the east.

•**The Nile Valley (Egypt):** A distinct, fertile river valley surrounded by natural desert barriers, allowing for a stable, localized, and long-lasting civilization.

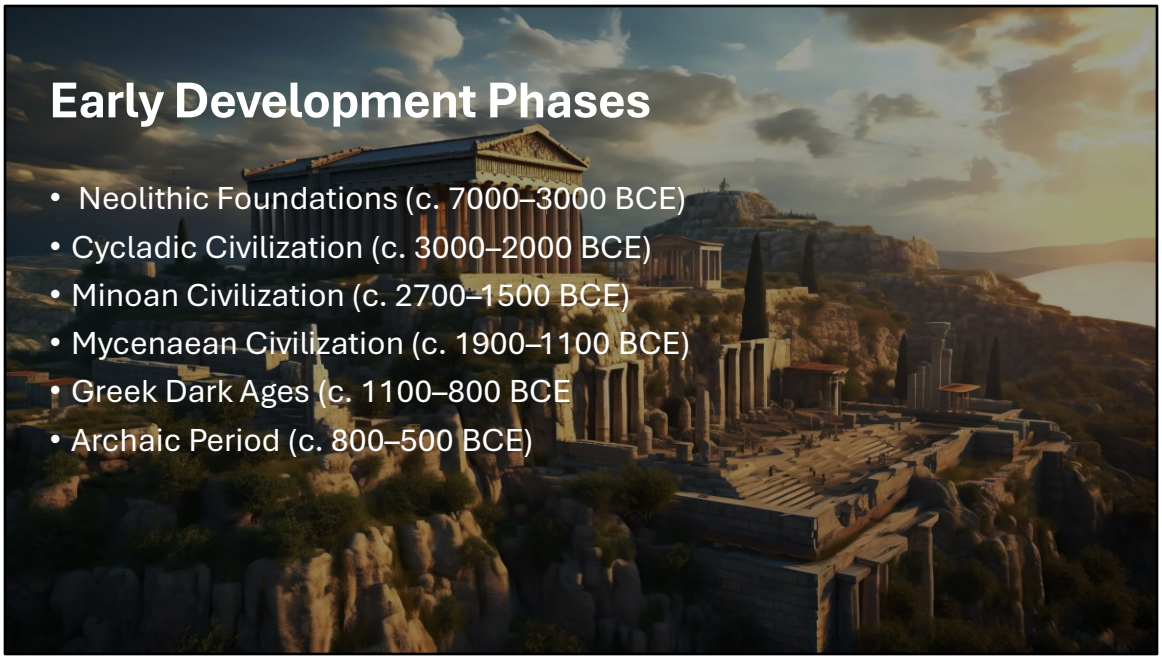
•**The Fertile Crescent:** A crescent-shaped region stretching from the Persian Gulf through the Levant and into Anatolia, noted for its arable land amidst drier surrounding areas.

•**Mountainous Barriers:** The Anatolian peninsula (Turkey) and the Zagros/Taurus mountain ranges to the north and east provided natural boundaries and sources for the rivers, often isolating civilizations while providing mineral resources.

- **Irrigation and Centralization**: The need to manage large-scale irrigation systems along the Tigris and Euphrates necessitated the development of centralized governments, complex bureaucracy, and social stratification.
- **Trade Routes**: The Near East, lacking sufficient timber, stone, and precious metals, relied on trade. Major trade routes like the King's Highway (skirting the desert) and the Way of the Sea (coastal route) connected Egypt with Mesopotamia and the Levant, fostering economic interaction.
- **Climate & Ecology**: While generally arid, the varied landscape included coastal plains, mountainous highlands, and marshes, leading to diverse local economies and specializations.
- **Natural Defenses**: The region's borders—the Mediterranean, the Arabian Desert, and the Caucasus mountains—offered protection but also created a "contested" space (particularly the Levant) where empires interacted, traded, and warred.



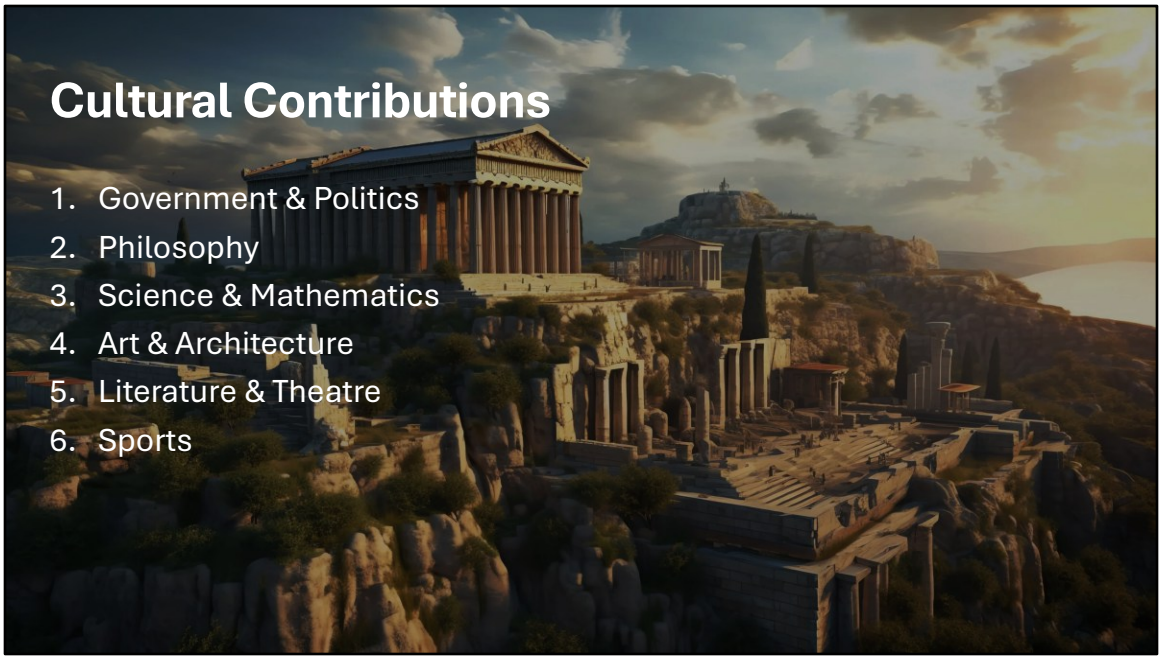
- Early Greek civilization developed from **Neolithic** settlements around 7000 BCE, transitioning into advanced Bronze Age cultures, *primarily* **the Minoans (c. 2700–1500 BCE) and Mycenaeans (c. 1900–1100 BCE), before the Archaic period (800–500 BCE) solidified city-states (poleis).**
- These early stages laid the foundation through Linear A/B writing, trade, palaces, and the Homeric epic.



- **Neolithic Foundations (c. 7000–3000 BCE):** The very first sedentary agricultural communities appeared in Greece, marking the transition from hunter-gatherers to farming.
- **Cycladic Civilization (c. 3000–2000 BCE):** Known for distinctive, abstract marble figurines, this culture flourished in the Aegean Islands.
- **Minoan Civilization (c. 2700–1500 BCE):** Based in Crete, this was the first advanced "palace" civilization in Europe, featuring maritime trade networks, refined art, and the undeciphered Linear A script.
- **Mycenaean Civilization (c. 1900–1100 BCE):** Known as the first true "Greek" civilization on the mainland, they were a warrior aristocracy. They adopted Linear B (early Greek) and built massive fortified palaces.
- **Greek Dark Ages (c. 1100–800 BCE):** Following the fall of Mycenaean civilization, this period saw population decline, abandonment of cities, and a reduction in

writing.

- **<u>Archaic Period</u> (c. 800–500 BCE):** Emerging from the Dark Ages, this period saw a population boom, the birth of the polis (city-state), adoption of the Phoenician alphabet, and the beginnings of monumental art.



•**Government & Politics:** Athens developed the first known democracy (*demokratia*), allowing adult male citizens to vote on laws in an Assembly. Other contributions include the concept of citizenship, trial by jury, and the term politics.

•**Philosophy:** Greek thinkers shifted from mythological explanations to rational, logical, and empirical observation. Key figures included Socrates (Socratic method), Plato (Academy), and Aristotle (Lyceum), who laid the groundwork for Western philosophy.

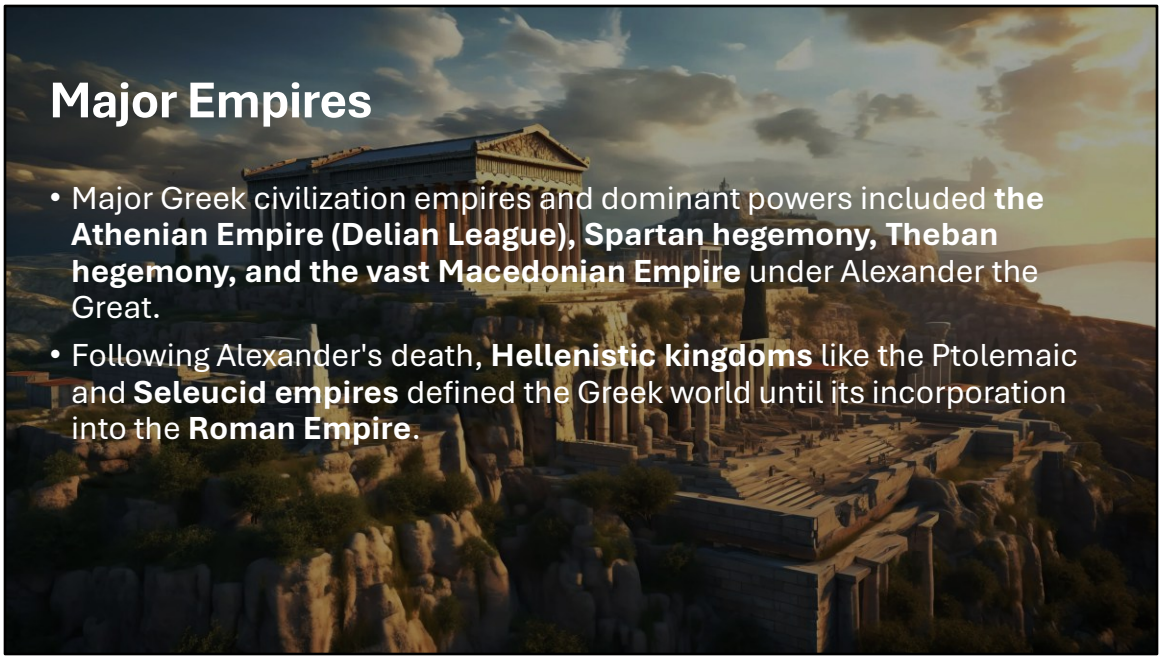
•**Science & Mathematics:** The Greeks made crucial advances in geometry (Euclid), physics and engineering (Archimedes), astronomy (Aristarchus's heliocentric model), and medicine (Hippocrates, known as the "father of medicine").

•**Art & Architecture:** Greek artists prioritized realism, ideal proportion, and the human form, famously utilizing the "golden ratio" in sculpture. Architecture is defined by the three classical orders (Doric, Ionic, Corinthian) and iconic structures like the

Parthenon.

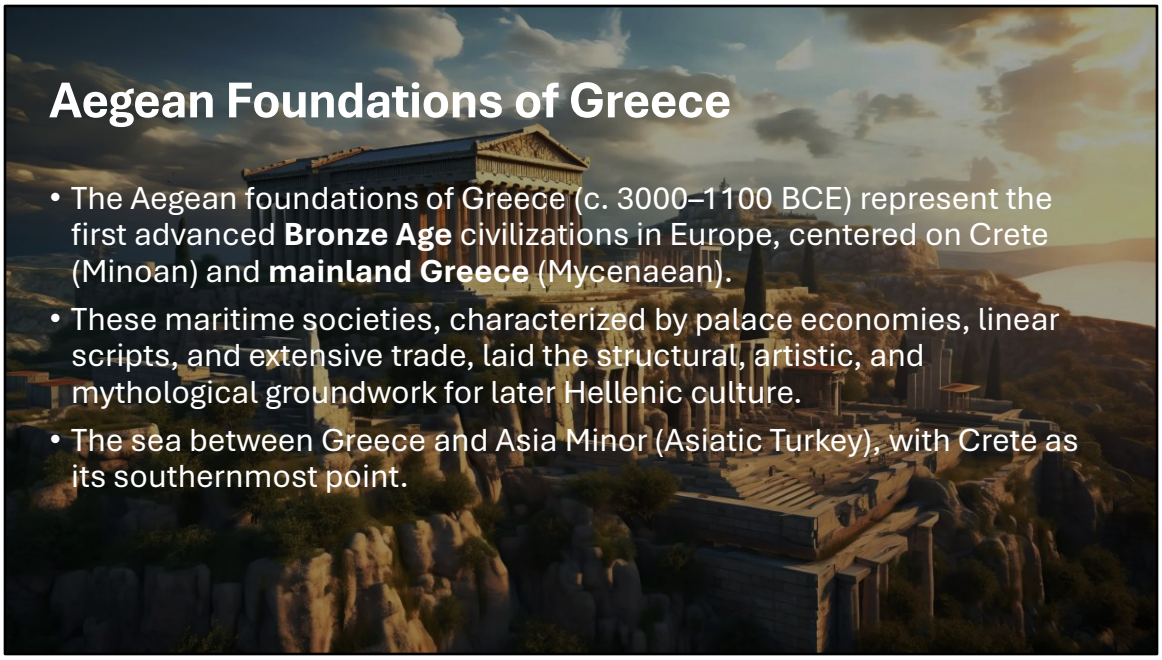
•**Literature & Theatre:** Greek drama originated in Athens, evolving from religious festivals into tragedies (Sophocles, Euripides) and comedies (Aristophanes). Epic poetry was defined by Homer's *Iliad* and *Odyssey*.

•**Sports:** The Greeks introduced state-mandated physical education and created the Olympic Ga

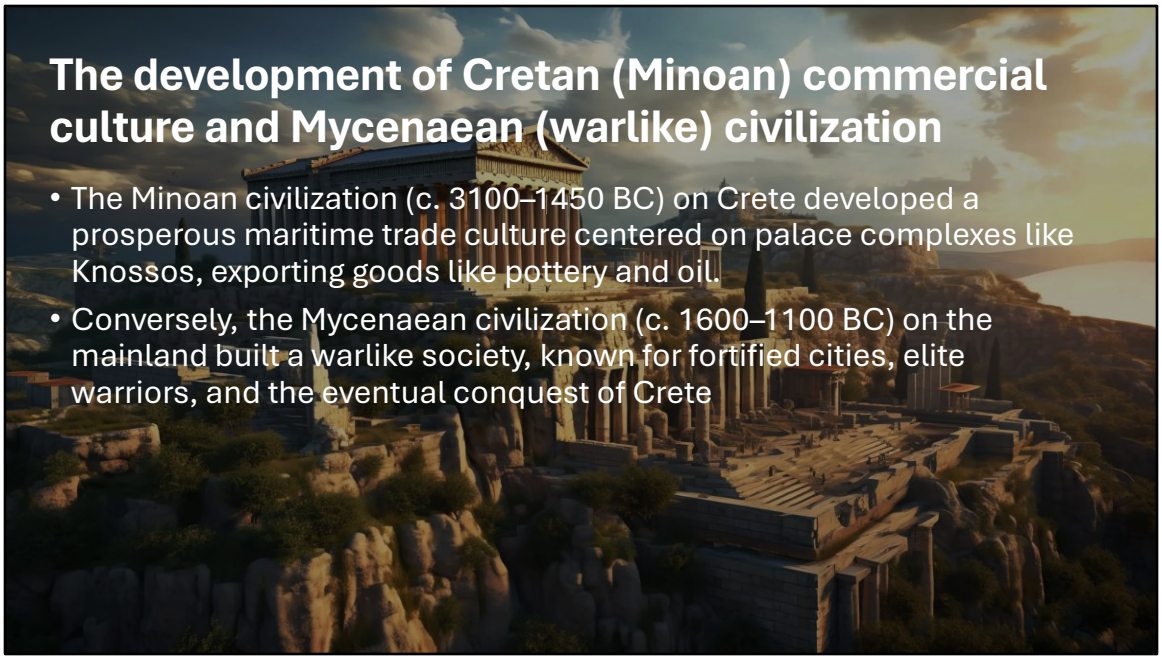


- Major Greek civilization empires and dominant powers included the Athenian Empire (Delian League), Spartan hegemony, Theban hegemony, and the vast Macedonian Empire under Alexander the Great.

- Following Alexander's death, Hellenistic kingdoms like the Ptolemaic and Seleucid empires defined the Greek world until its incorporation into the Roman Empire.



- The Aegean foundations of Greece (c. 3000–1100 BCE) represent the first advanced **Bronze Age** civilizations in Europe, centered on Crete (Minoan) and **mainland Greece** (Mycenaean).
- These maritime societies, characterized by palace economies, linear scripts, and extensive trade, laid the structural, artistic, and mythological groundwork for later Hellenic culture.
- The sea between Greece and Asia Minor (Asiatic Turkey), with Crete as its southernmost point.



<u>Minoan Civilization (Crete)</u>: Commercial and Artistic Hub

•**Rise & Economy:** Emerging around 3100 BC, Minoans created an advanced, trade-based society, often considered the first civilized culture in Europe. Their prosperity was driven by trade networks reaching Egypt and the Levant, exporting timber, olive oil, and wine in exchange for copper, gold, and ivory.

•**Culture:** Known for immense, unfortified palaces (like Knossos), they possessed a refined art style featuring colorful, motion-filled frescoes and intricate pottery.

•**Society & Writing:** They developed an early writing system, Linear A, and seem to have had a peaceful, seafaring culture (thalassocracy).

•**Decline:** The culture was weakened by natural disasters, specifically volcanic activity, allowing them to be taken over by Mycenaean Greeks around 1450 BC.

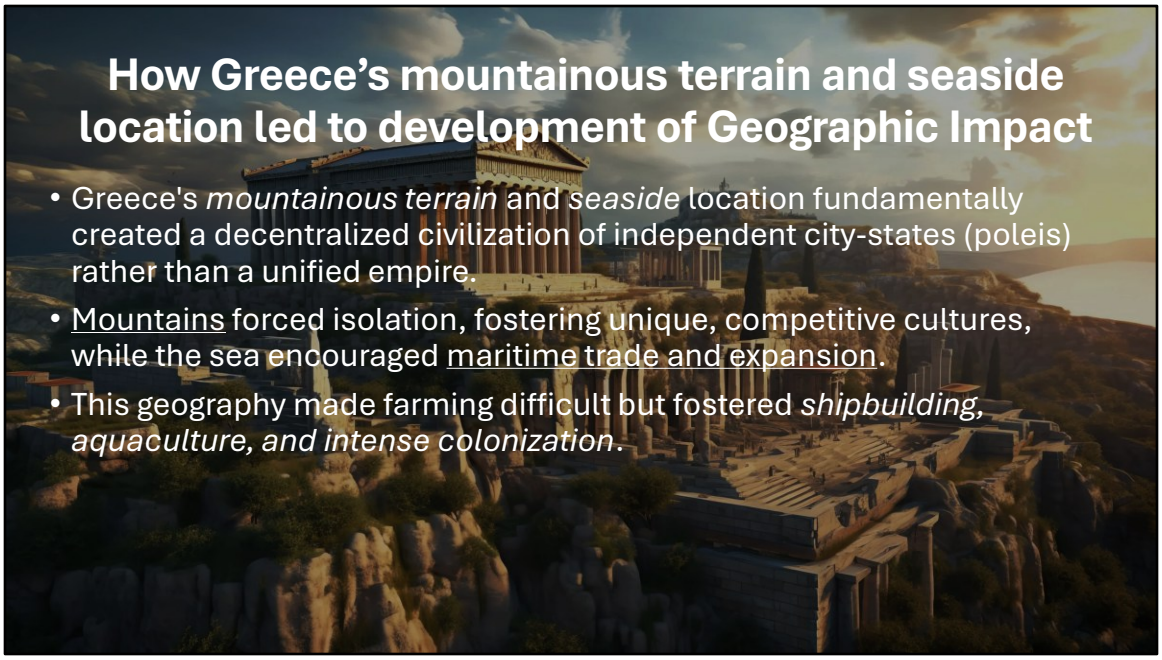
<u>Mycenaean Civilization (Mainland Greece)</u>: Warlike and Expansionist

•**Rise & Nature:** Appearing on the mainland around 1600 BC, the Mycenaeans were Indo-European warriors who established fortified cities (like Mycenae) in contrast to the open Minoan palaces.

•**Influence & Power:** They heavily borrowed from Minoan art, architecture, and their writing system (adapting it into Linear B).

•**Warfare & Trade:** They were an aristocratic society geared toward conquest and competition. Their economy was managed by the ruling class, specializing in exporting products like perfume and luxury goods, alongside importing metals.

•**Decline:** After dominating the Aegean, the Mycenaean civilization collapsed around 1100-1200 BC due to internal strife and invasions, leading to the Greek Dark Ages



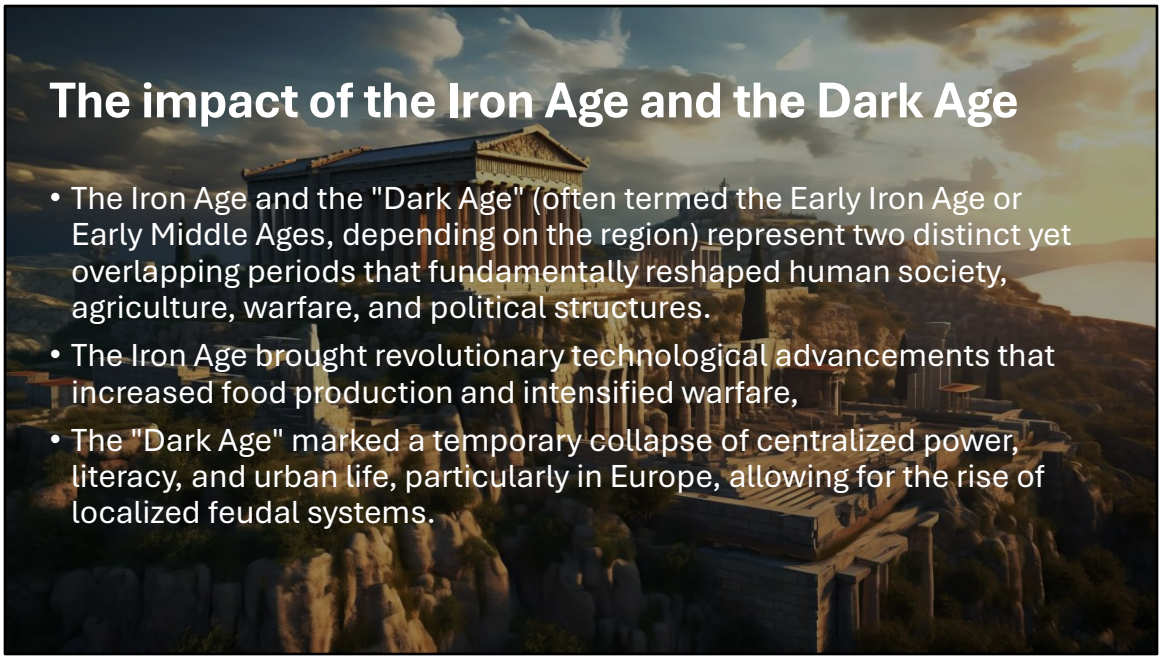
Geographic Impacts:

•**Political Fragmentation (Mountains):** The rugged, mountainous terrain made land communication and transport difficult, leading to isolated communities that developed into independent, often rival, city-states like Sparta and Athens.

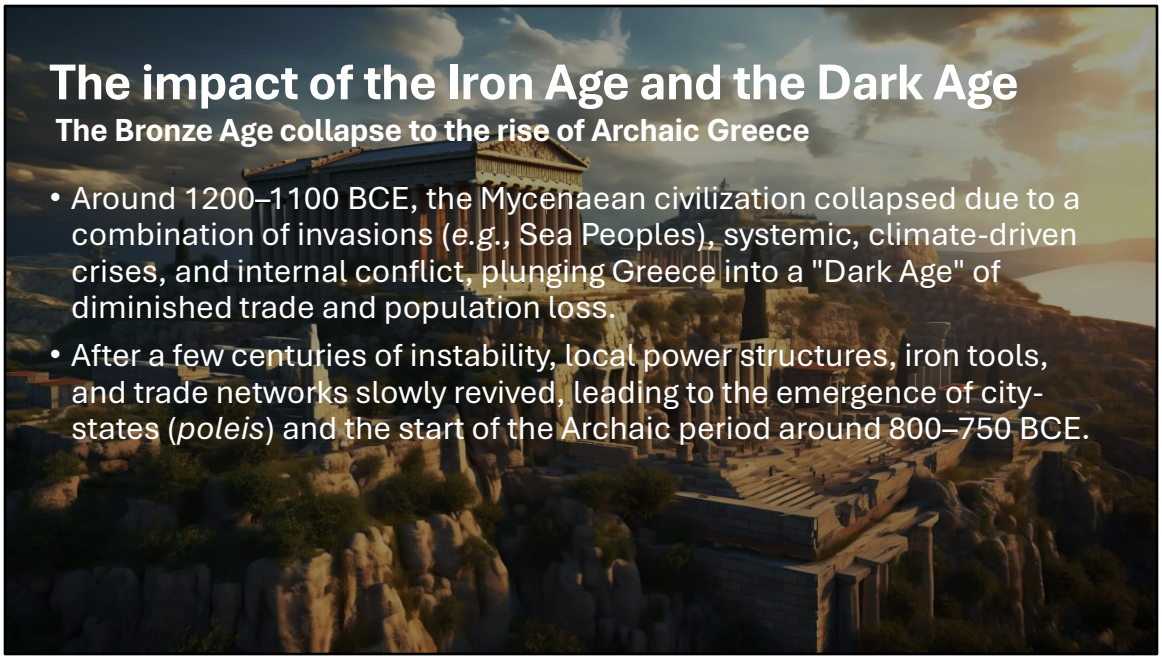
•**Maritime Orientation (Seaside/Islands):** Surrounded by the sea with limited land for agriculture, the Greeks became expert sailors, shipbuilders, and traders to survive and prosper.

•**Expansion and Colonization:** The scarcity of farmable land on the mountainous peninsula pushed Greeks to establish colonies across the Mediterranean and Black Sea regions, spreading their culture.

•**Unique Agricultural Economy:** The terrain proved better suited to growing olives and grapes rather than vast fields of grain, influencing their trade goods and diet



The Iron Age and the "Dark Age" (often termed the Early Iron Age or Early Middle Ages, depending on the region



The Bronze Age Collapse (~1200–1150 BCE)

•**A "Perfect Storm":** The collapse was likely not caused by one event, but a combination of climate change (droughts), widespread famine, systemic failures, and social unrest, exacerbated by the attacks of the "Sea Peoples".

•**End of Palaces:** The bureaucratic palace economies of the Mycenaeans were destroyed and abandoned.

•**Loss of Knowledge:** Writing (Linear B), large-scale construction, and specialized manufacturing vanished.

The Greek Dark Age (~1150–800 BCE)

•**Societal Shift:** Greece shifted from a centralized, palace-based society to fragmented, smaller agricultural communities.

•**Technological Shift:** The lack of tin (needed for bronze) forced the widespread adoption of iron, leading to improvements in tools and weapons.

•**Isolation & Decline:** Trade networks disappeared, resulting in reduced trade with the surrounding Mediterranean.

The Rise of Archaic Greece (~800–480 BCE)

•**The Rise of the Polis:** Towards the end of the 9th and early 8th centuries BCE, communities reorganized, giving rise to the city-state (polis) structure.

•**Cultural Revival:** The Greek alphabet was adopted from the Phoenicians, leading to the resurgence of writing, including the composition of the Homeric epics.

•**Colonization & Trade:** As population increased and resources were strained, Greeks began colonizing the Mediterranean and Black Sea areas, reviving trade, and using currency

Stages of Development:

•**Greek Colonization (Archaic Period):** Settlers established city-states (poleis) such as Miletus, Ephesus, and Smyrna along the Asia Minor coast, transforming the region into a bustling commercial and intellectual hub.

•**Hellenization (4th Century BCE onwards):** Following Alexander the Great's conquests, Greek culture, language, and urban planning spread throughout the Near East, forming the basis of Hellenistic culture.

•**Roman Annexation (2nd Century BCE - 1st Century CE):** Rome inherited regions like Pergamon (133 BCE), turning them into provinces. This period, particularly under *Pax Romana*, brought stability, infrastructure (roads), and blended traditions.

•**Regional Impact:** Cities like Ephesus flourished, becoming major centers of commerce, art, and intellectual life.

•**Transition to Byzantium:** After 476 CE, these regions shifted from Roman to Byzantine control, remaining a prosperous center of Greco-Roman culture in Asia until the Seljuq Turkish advance.

Core Cultural and Infrastructure Contributions:

•**Urbanization:** Introduction of the Agora (public space), theaters, and fortified city walls.

•**Infrastructure:** Extensive road networks and sophisticated aqueducts built by Roman engineers, as detailed in the National Geographic Society guide to Roman engineering.

•**Cultural Integration:** A blend of Greek philosophy and Roman administrative law, which created a unique "Greco-Roman" identity in the East.

Cultural and Religious Evolution

Greco-Roman North Africa was a mosaic of cultures.

•**Syncretism:** Punic and Berber cultures persisted alongside Roman influence, often blending, particularly in religious practices.

•**Christianity:** By the 3rd century CE, the region became a major center for early Christianity, home to influential figures like Tertullian, Cyprian, and St. Augustine of Hippo.

Decline and Transition (4th–7th Century CE)

•**Vandal Invasion (439 CE):** The Vandal kingdom disrupted Roman administration, leading to a period of decline, though they maintained some infrastructure.

•**Byzantine Reconquest (533 CE):** Emperor Justinian's forces reconquered the region, but Byzantine rule was marked by political instability and local revolts.

•**Islamic Conquest (7th Century CE):** The arrival of Arab armies at the end of the 7th century incorporated North Africa into the Umayyad Caliphate, ending the formal Greco-Roman era

Development and Key Stages

•**Greek Origins (c. 1800–146 BCE):** Greek culture matured from the Mycenaean period through the Archaic and Classical ages, establishing the *polis* (city-state), democracy, philosophy, and art.

•**Roman Ascent (c. 753–146 BCE):** Rome grew from a small Italian city-state into a republic, heavily influenced by its Etruscan neighbors and Greek colonies in Italy.

•**The Merging (146 BCE–476 CE):** After conquering Greece, Rome adopted Greek education, art, and philosophy, creating a "Graeco-Roman" culture that was disseminated across Europe. This era included the Pax Romana, enabling the spread of laws, roads, and literature.

•**Byzantine Continuation (330–1453 CE):** After the Western Empire fell, the Eastern Roman (Byzantine) Empire continued to fuse Roman administration with Greek

language and Orthodox Christianity, preserving the culture for another millennium.

Key Contributions and Legacy

•**Politics and Law:** The Roman Republic's structural foundation of codified laws (e.g., Twelve Tables) and Greek concepts of political accountability (democracy/oligarchy).

•**Infrastructure and Engineering:** Roman engineering breakthroughs, including concrete, aqueducts, and extensive road networks, unified Western Europe.

•**Language and Literature:** Latin became the foundation for Romance languages (French, Sp

Western Civilization
Greek Civilization
NEXT MEETING... PREFINAL EXAMINATION (ONLINE)